

Buc-ee's: Coming Soon to a Gas Tank and a Stomach Near You

by Lew Toulmin



Never heard of Buc-ee's? You will. Soon. It's another Southern phenomenon that is slowly moving North, taking over the country. Is it a Southern phenom like voter suppression, fire ants and killer bees? Or is it Southern like great literature, super food, and amazing music? Read on, and you decide.

I first discovered Buc-ee's 18 months ago when visiting some acreage I own in rural Alabama on the Styx River, with the only waterfall for 100 miles. (Hey, it's only 9 inches tall, but it IS a waterfall.) Approaching the property, east of Mobile on Interstate 10, I saw a huge traffic jam on the off-ramp. There is normally no traffic there, since it's in the middle of nowhere.

Astounded, I followed the slow-moving cars and saw a massive truck stop, but no trucks. There were 120 gas pumps, and hundreds of people streaming into a huge building, marked by a sign with a beaver-squirrel-chipmunk-rat-huh? on it, that said "Buc-ee's." Inside I found thousands of food items, clothes with the Buc-ee's logo, drinks, BBQ, baked goods, fudge, candied jalapeños, and a zillion knick-knacks. It was like a 7-11 on steroids, about 25 times larger than a typical convenience store.

Research revealed that Buc-ee's was founded in 1982 by Arch Aplin III of Texas, was named after Arch's boyhood nickname of "Bucky Beaver," has 32 locations in Texas, and is now expanding northward to Kentucky, Tennessee and Missouri, and along the Gulf Coast to Louisiana, Alabama, Georgia and Florida.

The closest Buc-ee's to Maryland will open in 2027 in Virginia off Interstate 64 at the Talleyville exit, east of Richmond. It will have 74,000 square feet on a 28-acre, \$6.5 million parcel, with 120 fueling stations, 557 parking spaces, 10 bus/RV spaces, 24 Tesla chargers, and over 300 employees – all paid at least \$18 per hour, and none with visible tattoos or piercings. It will be open 24/7/365. Like all Buc-ee's, there will be nowhere for employees or patrons to sit down. You must buy your food while you are fueling your car, then leave the store and eat in your car, either in the parking lot or on the road. More Virginia locations are planned.

So what's the big attraction? Why are 100+ million customers per year visiting the 43 Buc-ee's locations? Why is the private firm's revenue topping \$629 million per year?

Wait for it...

Bathrooms.

Yes, Buc-ee's has the cleanest bathrooms in America. After winning an award for this achievement in 2012, "Beaver" Aplin boasted that, "Buc-ee's will be the new 'Taj Ma-Stall' of Texas." Having visited many of the 145,000 gas station bathrooms in this country, all ranging from disgusting (most of them) to so-so, I think that "Beaver" is a genius. He has figured out that the vast majority of gas stations are owned and operated by men, that those men don't care about bathroom cleanliness, but that most travelers, especially women with families, really do.

And, the average large Buc-ee's has 30 urinals and 12 stalls for men, and 28 toilets for women. So there are rarely any lines.

AND, each toilet stall is fully enclosed and private, with a strong metal door.

AND, the toilets always work, are cleaned every few minutes, and always smell good!

Wow.

Other items about Buc-ee's:

- Humorous billboards along the Interstates pull in potential patrons: "Only 262 miles to Buc-ee's -- you can hold it!", "Restrooms that make Mom smile," "Let us plan your next potty," "Your throne awaits," "Top two reasons to stop at Buc-ee's: Number 1 and Number 2," and (my favorite), "Eat here, get gas."
- Some patrons have called Buc-ee's and asked for their bathroom design, so they can replicate it at home.
- Gas prices at Buc-ee's are low, usually almost as low as Sam's Club and always better than competitors such as Wawa, Marathon, Shell and BP. So Buc-ee's gross margins on gas are low, but gross profit margins on major label items (like Coke) are about 35%, and margins on Buc-ee's branded items (which constitute about 12% of the packaged food items) are about 40%. Overall net profits for the firm, after paying off the very high construction debts, are higher than the industry average, around 2%. But volume is the key to the firm's success.
- 18-wheeler trucks are prohibited, since the firm concentrates on cars, pickups and RVs, and "is not designed for large trucks" like Pilot Flying J, Love's, and TA Travel Centers.
- Store-branded jerky comes in 37 different flavors, including Buc-ee's Bohemian Garlic, Cherry Maple, and Ghost Pepper Jelly.

- The biggest seller at Buc-ee's is the Beaver Nuggets (I don't know why, since I think the Nuggets taste like sugar- and caramel-covered gravel).
- IMHO, the chopped brisket BBQ is the best item in the store. The baked items are so-so.

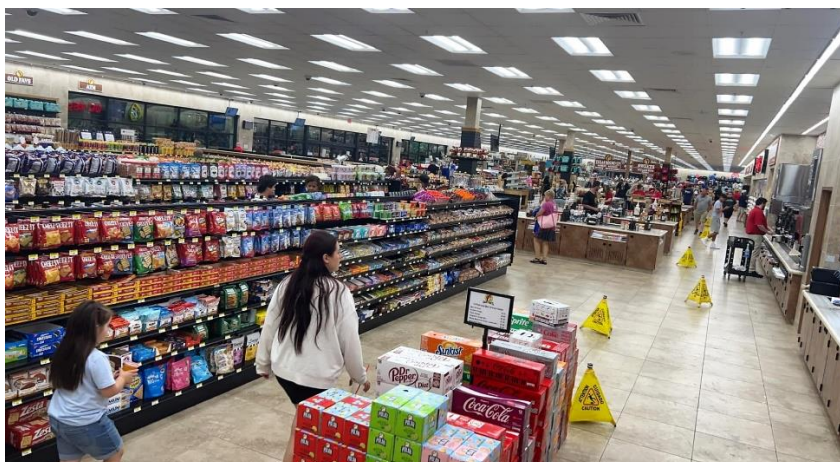
Final fun fact: Northern children love Buc-ee's and think of the stores as destinations they want to visit, like Disney World. So, Buc-ee's owns the future.



Words above: 825

Photos and captions:

1. Buc-ee's founder "Beaver" Aplin proudly views one of his many spotless bathrooms.
2. Large Buc-ee's travel centers have 60 to 120 gas pumps. This photo shows one of two gas pump areas at a typical store.
3. Inside, a Buc-ee's store seems to stretch to the horizon.



4. Buc-ee's mascot, a buck-toothed beaver (after the "Beaver" founder) poses with a patron.
5. Buc-ee's has sued numerous firms for trademark infringement. The most astounding case was when the Beaver sued the Choke Canyon BBQ Alligator, and won! This, despite the fact that the plaintiffs acknowledged that "even a four-year-old" could tell a brown beaver from a green alligator. Apparently the judge and jury in their wisdom thought that the fact that the figures were cartoons, were in a circle, were wearing hats, and had red tongues, was enough to reward the Beaver. (Texas justice?)
6. Buc-ee's Beaver Nuggets are considered addictive by many patrons. Why?
7. An employee at the Buc-ee's in Florence, South Carolina chops brisket BBQ, one of the best items in the store.
8. We have visited Buc-ee's in Baldwin County, AL, Daytona Beach and St. Augustine, FL, and Florence, SC, and every one was hiring, with wages as shown here. Note that the store manager gets \$150,000 to \$225,000 per year. Hmmmm....
9. Buc-ee's boasts three world records: longest car wash (in Denton, Texas, at 255 feet), largest convenience store, and largest gas station. The latter two are in Sevierville, Tennessee at 74,000 square feet, but will soon to be exceeded by a new one in Luling, Texas, at 75,000 square feet. (Texas pride and competitiveness!)

#end#

